

## The Genius of 'The Last Supper'

-Kashish Jaswani

Da Vinci's '*The Last Supper*' on first look seems simple – thirteen people dining together, reacting to some proclamation with Jesus Christ at the center. But as we delve deeper, questions arise, "What are the apostles reacting to?", "What do their emotions convey?" or simply, "What makes '*The Last Supper*' so great?"

What makes this painting so great is the mastermind of Leonardo Da Vinci. On examining, the first thing that draws attention is the contrast created on the table. Jesus in traditional red robes, head and eyes lowered, forming a calm center. Around him, twelve apostles seem disconcerted. This is because Jesus has declared, "One of you will betray me." His closest followers are shocked! St. Peter to Jesus' right, even rushes in with a knife to say, "Who is it?"

This is what Da Vinci does differently. He focuses on gestures and human emotion by simplifying everything else. Interestingly, the painting is not of a particular moment, rather, of successive moments.

The apostles are in four groups of three. On Jesus' left, Thomas points upwards, to say "Is this God's plan?" Philip and James the Major are in opposite motions, one throws his hands out and the other brings them together. The rest of the apostles whisper amongst themselves. The stance of every apostle is considered appropriate for their personality.

The moment when Jesus identifies the betrayer is brilliantly portrayed in the painting. Christ's right hand is widely stretched as he reaches towards the wine and the bowl. Whoever dips in the same bowl is the betrayer, and we see Judas' hand reach towards it. His face is cast in shadow and he pulls away with his neck turned to remind us he will hang himself. In his other hand he latches on to a bag of silver pieces given to him to betray Christ.

In the background, techniques "*chiaroscuro*" (gradual movement from dark to light) and "*Sfumato*" (blurring edges to produce soft outlines) are used. The latter, evident in '*The Mona Lisa*', another masterpiece of Da Vinci. The perspective lines converge towards a central point, giving an illusion of depth, making it clear that the center of the painting as well as the subject matter is Jesus.

Da Vinci began the painting in 1495 and took long pauses, completing in 1498. Instead of using a common method of the time 'fresco' (requiring quick application of paint), he tested with tempera and oil paint. But due to this experimentation, the painting began to flake and deteriorate within a few years.

Despite several restoration attempts since the 1700s, real results could only be achieved in 1999 by Pinin Brambilla Barcilon who was appointed to oversee a full repair. Today, it is back to where it was originally, at the convent of Santa Maria delle Grazie in Milan.

Leonardo was successful in conveying his message even in the simplicity of this painting. It is no wonder that out of all depictions of 'The Last Supper', his is so widely remembered even after 600 years.